I said she should skip the engagement, of course. I needed to go, make a quick appearance, but I'd be home fast.

No, she insisted, she didn't trust herself to be at home alone for even an hour with such dark feelings.

So we put on our best kit, and she applied dark, dark lipstick to draw attention away from her bloodshot eyes, and out of the door we went.

The car pulled up outside the Royal Albert Hall, and as we stepped into the blue flashing lights of the police escort and the whiteout lights of the press's flashbulbs, Meg reached for my hand. She gripped it tightly. As we went inside, she gripped it even tighter. I was buoyed by the tightness of that grip. She's hanging on, I thought. Better than letting go.

But when we settled into the royal box, and the lights dimmed, she let go of her emotions. She couldn't hold back the tears. She wept silently.

The music struck up, we turned and faced the front. We spent the entire length of the performance (Cirque du Soleil) squeezing each other's hands, me promising her in a whisper:

Trust me. I'll keep you safe.

61.

I WOKE TO a text from Jason.

Bad news.

What is it now?

The *Mail on Sunday* had printed the private letter Meg had written to her father. The letter that Granny and Pa urged her to write.

February 2019.

I was in bed, Meg was lying next to me, still asleep.

I waited a bit, then broke the news to her softly.

Your father's given your letter to the Mail.

No.

Meg, I don't know what to say, he's given them your letter.